

A CANDID GUIDE TO
BALDUR'S GATE

For Those Who Would Rather Know Than Wonder

"Commerce is the only law that Baldur's Gate has ever truly obeyed."

— Common saying among the city's merchants

Welcome to Baldur's Gate

You have arrived at the greatest city on the Sword Coast. It is loud, crowded, occasionally dangerous, and entirely unlike anywhere else you have ever been. It will try to pick your pocket within the first hour. I am telling you this because the official guides will not, and you deserve to know what you have walked into.

Baldur's Gate is a city of contradictions. It is enormously wealthy and desperately poor. It is governed by laws that are selectively enforced and ignored with equal enthusiasm. It welcomes everyone and trusts no one. It has survived invasions, plagues, political coups, and at least three separate attempts by various factions to burn it to the ground, and it has emerged from each one larger, louder, and more convinced of its own importance than before.

This guide was not prepared by anyone with authority to prepare it. It carries no seal, no official sanction, and no author's name, for reasons that will become apparent as you read. The goal is simply to tell you the truth about a city that produces very little of it in written form. Use it accordingly.

A Note From the Author

I have lived in this city for longer than I intend to admit. I have watched it eat people who arrived unprepared and reward people who understood what it actually was. The official guides — when the city bothers to produce them — describe a place of commerce and opportunity that is technically accurate and practically useless. This guide describes the city as it is. I have no authority to publish it, which is why it carries no name. Read it carefully and you will arrive better prepared than most.

A Brief History

The City's Origins

Baldur's Gate takes its name from Balduran, a legendary explorer and merchant captain whose voyages to distant lands brought back wealth enough to build the original city walls. The gate itself — the grand arch that still stands at the harbor — was funded by Balduran's final return voyage, and the city that grew up around it has never stopped thinking of itself as a place defined by what arrives from the sea.

For most of its early history, Baldur's Gate was exactly what it looked like: a trading port. Ships came in, goods changed hands, coin moved, ships went out. The city's founding families — the patriars, as they came to be called — grew rich managing this trade and richer still managing the people who managed the trade. The essential character of the city was established early and has not changed much since. Everything here is for sale. The only question is the price.

The Rise of the Council

Baldur's Gate is governed by the Council of Four — three dukes and one grand duke, currently Ulder Ravengard, Marshal of the Flaming Fist. Ravengard's control of the city's military arm gives him practical authority his fellow dukes cannot easily challenge. In the case of a tied council vote, the grand duke's vote counts twice, which tells you most of what you need to know about how power actually works here.

Advising the Council is the Parliament of Peers, a body of nearly fifty members drawn mainly from the patriarch families. The Parliament debates matters of law and governance at considerable length before presenting its majority position to the Council for a final vote. Common belief holds that many parliament members — and possibly one or more of the dukes — can be bribed for their votes. The more interesting wrinkle is that those who accept bribes are not particularly afraid of legal reprisal. They are afraid of being perceived as incompetent by their peers. The result is an elaborate and widely understood system in which bribe money is converted into cheap jewelry or false art objects, which are then purchased at inflated prices. Everyone involved understands what is happening. No one says so directly.

The Flaming Fist serves as the city's military arm — mercenaries under contract to the Council, better trained than most city guards and considerably more expensive. They keep the major roads safe, the harbor functional, and the worst violence off the streets of the Upper City. What happens below the bridge is, in practice, somewhat less their concern.

The City Today

Baldur's Gate is the largest city on the Sword Coast and one of the largest in Faerûn. It is a city of roughly one hundred thousand souls — more, if you count the Outer City that has sprawled beyond the walls without anyone officially acknowledging that it exists. It handles more trade volume than any other port city in the region and it is not modest about this fact.

Politically, the city is in its usual state of managed tension. The patriarchs of the Upper City maintain their privileges with the casual confidence of people who have never had to question them. The merchants of the Lower City keep the money moving and occasionally push for representation that never quite materializes. The residents of the Outer City continue to exist in the gaps between both, largely ignored by the governance that nominally covers them. The Guild — the city's preeminent criminal organization — operates openly enough that most residents treat it as an unofficial branch of civic administration, which is not entirely inaccurate.

The City and Its Districts

Baldur's Gate is divided by geography, wealth, and the ancient wall that separates the Upper City from everything below it. Understanding which part of the city you are in is the most important navigational skill a visitor can develop, because the rules — written and unwritten — are different in each.

The Upper City

Home to the patriarchs, the Grand Dukes, the finest temples, and the most expensive real estate on the Sword Coast. The streets are clean, the buildings are stone, and entry requires either a patriarch's invitation, proof of legitimate business, or enough gold to satisfy the gate guards that you belong. Visitors who cannot produce any of the above are turned away politely but firmly.

The Lower City

Where the actual city lives. Merchants, craftsmen, sailors, laborers, and everyone in between crowd into a dense warren of streets that runs from the harbor to the base of the Upper City wall. The Lower City is loud, busy, and alive in a way that some cities are not. It is also under considerable strain — rampant crime, class tensions, foreign pressures, and Flaming Fist patrols that respond to threats with indiscriminate violence have left many residents feeling unsafe in their own streets. In recent years, citizens

	have begun banding together in neighborhood crews, doing their best to protect their territories where the Fist does not. Whether this has made the Lower City safer or simply more armed is a matter of ongoing debate.
The Outer City	The sprawl beyond the walls that the city officially pretends does not exist. No Flaming Fist patrols, no civic services, no legal protections worth mentioning. The Outer City houses the tanneries, the slaughterhouses, the refugees, and the people who cannot afford even the Lower City's rents. It is not without its own economy and its own social structures — it simply operates entirely outside the city's formal governance. Visitors are advised to go with purpose and leave before dark.
The Harbour	The economic heart of everything. Ships from across Faerûn and beyond dock here daily. The harbour district runs continuously — there is no hour at which it is truly quiet. Warehouses, counting houses, ship chandlers, fish markets, and every manner of dockside establishment line the waterfront. The smell is an experience.
The Wide	The great open market square of the Lower City, where the majority of the city's day-to-day commerce happens. Permanent stalls, temporary vendors, street performers, and the occasional brawl share the space in rough harmony. If you need something and you cannot find it in the Wide, you may need to ask the Guild.
Bloomridge	The wealthiest neighborhood of the Lower City — an aspiration made of stone and well-trimmed hedges. Merchants who have done well enough to want their neighbors to know it live here. The Flaming Fist patrols regularly and the streets are among the safest in the Lower City. Prices reflect this.

Powers and Factions

Baldur's Gate has no shortage of organizations, guilds, and factions competing for influence, money, and the occasional monopoly on violence. A visitor who understands who the major players are will navigate the city considerably better than one who does not.

The Flaming Fist

The city's contracted military force, headquartered at Wyrms Rock fortress at the eastern approach to the city. The Flaming Fist are professional soldiers — better equipped and better disciplined than most city guards, and considerably more expensive to bribe. They are the primary law enforcement presence in the Upper City and the harbor, and a visible if somewhat thinner presence in the Lower City.

The Fist operates on a straightforward mandate: keep the trade flowing and the major violence contained. Their patrols focus on the Lower City, though they hold nominal authority over the Outer City as well. They are generally effective at both. They are less effective at anything requiring nuance or selective enforcement of laws that disadvantage the wealthy. The Fist has been known

to hire independent agents when its ranks are spread thin — which happens more often than the city's official communications suggest.

The Watch is an entirely separate force, bankrolled by the patriars and existing solely to serve them. Watch officers spend entire careers within the Upper City and pride themselves on recognizing every Upper City resident by sight. At dusk the Watch clears the Upper City of everyone except residents, household staffs, and guests bearing written invitations. Visitors who find themselves in the Upper City after dark without the right paperwork will meet the Watch quickly and leave the Upper City shortly thereafter.

The Guild

Baldur's Gate's preeminent criminal organization is not a secret. Everyone knows it exists, most people know roughly what it does, and a significant portion of the city's residents have some kind of working relationship with it. The Guild controls the majority of the city's illegal trade — which in Baldur's Gate is a category that expands and contracts depending on who is currently on the Council — and takes a percentage of enough legitimate commerce that the line between criminal organization and merchant association is genuinely unclear.

Visitors are unlikely to have direct contact with the Guild unless they go looking for it or do something that attracts its attention. The former is possible — the Guild provides services that the city's legitimate establishments cannot or will not — but should be approached with the understanding that the Guild's contracts are enforced with more consistency than the city's laws, and its penalties for non-compliance are proportionally severe.

The Patriars

The old noble families of Baldur's Gate have held their position for generations through a combination of inherited wealth, strategic marriage, political maneuvering, and the occasional well-timed removal of a competitor. They are not technically a unified faction — the patriarch families compete with each other as often as they cooperate — but they share a common interest in maintaining the systems that keep them at the top of the city's social order, and they cooperate effectively whenever that interest is threatened.

Most visitors will not interact directly with the patriars. Those who do should bring money, patience, and a willingness to be looked at with polite condescension by people whose ancestors were doing the same thing to other people's ancestors several hundred years ago.

The Harpers

The Harpers maintain a quiet but genuine presence in Baldur's Gate. They do not advertise. They do not recruit openly. They work through intermediaries, dead drops, and the kind of relationships that develop over years of shared trust and mutual benefit. Their interests in the city center on the usual Harper concerns — preventing concentrations of power that destabilize regions, monitoring threats that the city's official governance is either unaware of or actively ignoring, and occasionally extracting someone from a situation that has gone badly wrong.

Those who need Harper assistance in Baldur's Gate are generally directed toward the Elfsong Tavern in the Lower City, where a contact named Mari Al'maren can be found on the top floor. She was born in Elturel and raised by a Harper bard, and has operated in the city long enough that her network is considerably deeper than her unassuming presence suggests. She is quick to laugh and quick to anger, treats people exactly as well as they treat her, and is not interested in wasting time on visitors who cannot tell her something worth knowing.

A Note on the Guild and the Law

The relationship between the Guild, the Flaming Fist, and the city's laws is complicated in ways that are difficult to explain briefly. The short version is this: in Baldur's Gate, whether something is legal is less important than whether it is tolerated, and what is tolerated varies by district, by who you are, and by who is currently in whose debt. Visitors who come from cities with more consistent legal environments are advised to ask before assuming, and to ask someone who actually knows the answer rather than someone who merely has an opinion.

Commerce and Trade

The Market and the Wide

The Wide operates every day without exception — rain, celebration, civic emergency, or the aftermath of the previous night's violence. It is the commercial center of the Lower City and one of the busiest market spaces on the Sword Coast. Visitors will find goods from across Faerûn traded here, alongside the products of the city's own craftsmen and the inevitable array of items whose provenance is best not examined too closely.

Prices in the Wide are negotiable in a way that the shops of Bloomridge are not. Vendors expect haggling and have built their initial prices accordingly. A buyer who accepts the first number offered is leaving money on the table and will be silently judged for it. A buyer who haggles past the point of reason will find their vendor suddenly very busy with other customers.

The Harbour Trade

The harbour handles the volume of trade that makes Baldur's Gate what it is. Ships dock from Waterdeep to the north, Amn to the south, and ports that most of the city's residents could not locate on a map. The harbour masters manage berth assignments, cargo inspections, and the endless paperwork that international commerce requires. They are efficient, moderately honest, and open to reasonable discussions about expedited processing for a reasonable administrative fee.

Merchants with significant cargo to move should engage a factor — a local agent who knows the harbour, its people, and its rhythms well enough to navigate both the official processes and the unofficial ones. A good factor is worth their commission many times over. A bad one is an expensive lesson. Ask for references.

Notable Establishments

The following establishments are noted for quality, reliability, or simple notoriety. No official body endorses any of them. Some of them the Grand Dukes would prefer not to acknowledge at all.

- The Elfsong Tavern — The finest and most famous inn in the Lower City. Expensive by Lower City standards, excellent by any standard, and home to the disembodied voice of an elven ghost who occasionally fills the tavern with a melancholy song about a lover lost at sea. Most patrons stop speaking when she sings and resume only after she stops. Many regulars come as much for the chance of hearing her as for anything else. The proprietor is a half-elf named Alan Alyth who has run the establishment for decades and whose opinion of adventurers is best described as cautiously skeptical. The top floor is where the interesting conversations happen, if you know who to ask for.

- The Low Lantern — A floating tavern moored at the harbour, three decks of increasingly rowdy entertainment. Popular with sailors, off-duty Flaming Fist soldiers, and anyone who wants to drink somewhere that does not pretend to have standards it does not actually maintain. Cheap, loud, and surprisingly safe given its reputation.
 - Sorcerous Sundries — The premier magical goods establishment in the city, located in the Upper City. An extraordinary selection of legitimate magical items, components, and services. Prices match the quality and the location. Access requires legitimate business or a patriarch's introduction.
 - The Counting House — The city's primary banking institution, operated by the Goldsmiths' Guild. Secure, discreet, and available to anyone with sufficient funds to make an account worthwhile. Letters of credit issued here are accepted in most major cities in Faerûn.
 - Chanterelle's — A restaurant in Bloomridge that has been feeding the city's wealthy for three generations. The food is exceptional. The waiting list for a table is two weeks. Walk-ins are turned away without exception, including walk-ins who claim to know someone.
 - The Black Gull — A tavern in the Outer City that serves as an informal employment exchange for mercenaries, guides, and people with skills that do not fit neatly into the city's licensed trade structures. No questions asked. No answers guaranteed. Useful if you know what you are looking for.
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Laws and Order

How Law Actually Works Here

Baldur's Gate has a substantial body of written law accumulated over several centuries of governance. Much of it is reasonable. Some of it is contradictory. A small but significant portion of it exists primarily to give the Flaming Fist flexibility in dealing with situations the original lawmakers could not have anticipated. The relationship between the written law and the law as it is actually practiced is a subject that occupies the city's lawyers considerably and rewards careful study by anyone who intends to stay long.

The practical rules for visitors are simpler than the written law suggests. Do not commit violence in the Upper City. Do not steal from patriarchs or their households. Do not interfere with Flaming Fist operations. Do not attract the kind of attention that makes powerful people feel threatened. Everything else is negotiable, contextual, and subject to the persuasive power of coin, connection, or a sufficiently compelling argument delivered to the right person.

The Flaming Fist and You

The Flaming Fist operates on a bounty system for certain categories of criminal activity, which means their enforcement priorities are shaped partly by what is profitable to enforce. Visitors who find themselves in legal difficulty have options: they can pay the fine, which is the most common resolution; they can request formal adjudication before a magistrate, which takes time and costs more; or they can leave the city quickly, which the Fist generally considers an acceptable outcome for minor infractions.

Visitors carrying weapons — which describes a significant portion of the people who come to Baldur's Gate for reasons other than pure commerce — should keep them sheathed in populated areas and be prepared to demonstrate legitimate purpose if questioned. The Fist does not generally confiscate weapons from people who are not causing trouble. They simply like to know that the option exists if that changes.

On Violence

Baldur's Gate has a higher tolerance for violence than most cities of comparable size, partly by necessity and partly by tradition. Brawls in the Lower City are common enough to be unremarkable. Dueling, while not formally legal, is practiced openly enough that the Flaming Fist generally declines to intervene in consensual engagements between parties who both seem capable of defending themselves. What the city does not tolerate is collateral damage — violence that spills onto bystanders, destroys property, or disrupts commerce. That brings the Fist quickly and in numbers.

Faith and the Temples

Baldur's Gate is not a particularly devout city in the civic sense — there is no dominant faith, no Companion, no tradition of public religious observance baked into the city's character. What there is, is a broad and functional tolerance for most faiths and an equally broad and functional indifference to most of them. Worship here is a private matter, which suits the city's general philosophy that most things are private matters unless they interfere with commerce.

The Major Temples

- The High Hall of Wonders — A temple to Gond, god of craft and invention, and one of the most visited temples in the city by virtue of its extraordinary collection of mechanical curiosities and magical constructs on public display. Worth seeing regardless of your faith.
- The Temple of Umberlee — Located at the harbour, as befits the goddess of the sea. Sailors in Baldur's Gate take Umberlee seriously in the way that people who spend significant time on the ocean take the ocean seriously. The temple receives more sincere offerings than almost any other in the city.
- The Dead Three — Bane, Bhaal, and Myrkul are collectively called the Dead Three, and while open worship of any of them is frowned upon in Baldur's Gate, it is not technically illegal so long as it remains within the city's other laws. This distinction matters more than it should. Followers of Bane tend to be patriars and gang leaders who favor dominance and control — they often wear black gloves as a subtle nod to Bane's holy symbol. Followers of Myrkul are fewer in number but quietly wealthy, typically those with an interest in the dead and the knowledge that can be extracted from them. And then there is Bhaal.
- Bhaal in Baldur's Gate — The Lord of Murder has a particular pull on this city that most residents prefer not to examine too closely. Few openly admit to worshiping him, but there is an unspoken assumption that anyone who benefits from violent death has some respect for Bhaal. His followers mark themselves by carving a fresh gouge on their thumbs — a subtle identification among allies that passes unnoticed among everyone else. Rumors persist of a temple to Bhaal existing somewhere beneath the city, possibly under the sewers or carved into Dusthawk Hill. The rumors also hold that eleven red crystals on the temple walls grow brighter with every murder committed in the city. Whether any of this is true is something the Flaming Fist claims to be investigating and the Harpers claim to already know.
- The Temple of Tymora — Lady Luck's house is well-attended in a city where fortune plays as large a role as skill in determining outcomes. Located in the Lower City, open to all, and practically oriented in a way that suits its congregation of gamblers, merchants, and adventurers.
- The House of the Wandering Eye — A temple to Selune, the moon goddess, known for its welcome to travelers, refugees, and those who have lost their way. One of the few temples in the city that provides practical assistance — food, temporary shelter, guidance — to those who need it regardless of their ability to pay.

On Religion in the Outer City

The Outer City has its own religious life, largely disconnected from the established temples of the Lower and Upper City. Shrines to a broad range of deities — some mainstream, some obscure, some of uncertain legitimacy — are scattered throughout the Outer City neighborhoods. Some of these shrines serve genuine communities of worship. Others are operated by people who have identified spiritual need as a commercial opportunity. Visitors are advised to engage with Outer City religious establishments with the same discernment they would apply to any other transaction in that part of the city.

Practical Information for Visitors

Getting Around

Baldur's Gate is a large city built on uneven terrain, with the Upper City sitting on a bluff above the Lower City and the harbour at the water's edge below everything. The elevation changes are significant and the streets do not always run in directions that make geometric sense — the city grew organically over centuries and its layout reflects that history more than any planning principle. Sedan chairs for hire are available throughout the Upper and Lower City for those who prefer not to navigate the hills on foot. Horses are permitted in most areas but the streets of the Lower City are congested enough that a horse is often slower than walking. Wagons and carts are restricted from the Upper City except during designated delivery hours.

Entry and Exit

By Sea

The harbour is open continuously. All arriving vessels must check in with the harbour master's office before unloading cargo or passengers. Passenger ships from Waterdeep, Amn, and points up and down the Sword Coast arrive regularly. The harbour master's fees are posted at the dock office.

By Road

The Coast Way connects the city to the north and south. The city's land gates are open from dawn to two hours past sunset. After-hours entry is available through the Basilisk Gate for a fee. The roads are patrolled by the Flaming Fist as far as a day's ride in either direction.

Safety by District

Upper City

Safest district in the city. Flaming Fist presence is heavy and consistent. Entry is controlled. Crime occurs but is handled quickly and quietly.

Lower City

Generally safe in daylight in the main commercial areas. Increases in risk after dark and in the narrower residential streets. Stay aware and keep valuables secured.

The Harbour

Variable. The main docks and commercial areas are well-patrolled. The edges of the harbour district, especially after dark, are considerably less so.

The Outer City

No Flaming Fist presence. Safety depends entirely on local knowledge, personal capability, and the specific neighborhood. Do not go alone if you do not know the area.

Accommodation

The Upper City has several excellent inns catering to wealthy merchants and travelers with patriarch connections, but access to these establishments generally requires the same credentials as access to the district itself. Most visitors stay in the Lower City, where the range of accommodation runs from the exceptional to the functional to the places where you keep your boots on while you sleep.

- The Elfsong Tavern — the standard recommendation for travelers who want quality and do not mind paying for it
- The Blade and Stars — a reliable mid-range option in the Lower City, popular with traveling merchants
- The Three Old Kegs — affordable, clean enough, and well-regarded among people who are watching their coin
- The Blushing Mermaid — cheaper still, at the harbour's edge, and the sort of establishment where you will hear interesting things if you listen carefully

A Final Word on the City

Baldur's Gate will take from you what you let it take and give back what you are capable of claiming. It is not a city that nurtures or protects or provides in the way that some cities do. It is a city that presents opportunity in roughly equal measure to risk and leaves the outcome to you.

Most people who come here for a purpose leave having accomplished it, having learned something they did not expect, and having spent more coin than they planned. Most people who come here without a purpose find one quickly, whether or not it was the one they would have chosen.

It is, in the end, the kind of city that leaves a mark. That is either a recommendation or a warning, depending on who you are.

May your purse stay full, your enemies stay slow, and your name stay out of the wrong conversations.

Circulated without official sanction. Author unknown. Keep it out of sight in the Upper City.